meeting in Moscow. Speaking off the cuff, the Russian complained of Ulbricht's 'ill-considered steps against you (Honecker) and other comrades in the Politburo'. Interestingly, he also asserted that 'there shouldn't be a process of reconciliation between the FRG and the GDR'. While Brezhnev recognised Honecker's zeal and energy, he was reluctant to intervene in the SED power struggle, given some in the higher levels of the Soviet government considered Honecker distinctly suspect and 'even more unpredictable and unreliable than Ulbricht'. With that in mind, Brezhnev continued to explore whether there was an alternative to Honecker. (Abrasimov was sent as a type of roving envoy to gauge opinion among SED old hands. Remarkably, even Willi Stoph, albeit grudgingly, recommended Honecker).15 Meanwhile, during their discussions, Brezhnev took pains to stress he was 'not in favour of simply pushing Walter aside, even considering the new situation in the Politburo of the SED'. His message was clear: Honecker needed to garner more support within the Politburo before he would act.16 According to Klaus Taubert, a reporter for the state news agency ADN, Honecker's future was already decided. 'His qualities were obvious. He was a staunch Stalinist. If he'd had an order, he'd obey, uncompromising. He'd stop at nothing.'17

Though outwardly united, throughout the summer of 1970, Honecker's contempt towards Ulbricht bubbled furiously. He did, nevertheless, smile for the cameras in Moscow during August when the First Secretary won a cheery public reception, but in a whispered conversation on 19 August, Brezhnev privately expressed concerns to Honecker about both Ulbricht and Willy Brandt. The latter, he said, was 'penetrating socialist countries, including the GDR' through the economy,18 with the aim of 'shaking' the German Democratic Republic. 'Neither we nor you,' he warned, 'can remain indifferent to such a danger.'19 It was useful, of course, to also know that Brezhnev deplored Ulbricht's boasting that East Germany would outdo the FRG's economy, saying his oft-used slogan of 'overtaking the West' was wrong. 'Our social order is of a different, higher type. We put the principles of humanism into practice.'20 It became evident that Brezhnev was clearly behind Honecker for the first time. As if briefing a statesman-in-the-making, Brezhnev insisted the future of the GDR lay in the socialist community. 'We have our troops there. That's a good thing and it will stay that way,' he added fiercely.21